

Unlearning Misogynoir

Recognizing and unlearning bias against Black women

4 lenses · tips & action steps — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Recognizing and unlearning bias against Black women

Misogynoir — the crossing of racism and sexism aimed at Black women — lodges in ordinary automatics: judging them more harshly, seeing them as ‘aggressive’ or ‘too much’, hypersexualizing them, not believing them. You can hold it without realizing.

This guide helps you spot and unlearn it. Here too: impact matters more than intention.

Your intention

A moment when you judged or treated a Black woman differently (not necessarily on purpose):

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Where these stereotypes come from

‘Strong woman who absorbs everything’, ‘angry woman’, hypersexualization, the ‘adultification’ of Black girls: these stereotypes have a history (media, colonial legacies) and are learned.

Knowing them lets you spot when they're driving your reactions.

Example

Manon realized she found a Black colleague ‘aggressive’ for contributions she’d have called ‘confident’ in someone else. The double standard jumped out.

Stereotypes I know

What stereotypes about Black women have you heard — or repeated yourself?

The double standard

A situation where you judged a Black woman more harshly than another person for the same thing?

→ *These stereotypes are learned — I can learn to spot them.*

The double standard in action

‘Aggressive’ where another would be ‘assertive’, ‘difficult’ where another would be ‘demanding’, not believing her, expecting her to be flawless: these are two stacked biases (race + gender).

Spotting them means no longer taking your reactions as self-evident.

Example

When a Black team member flagged a problem, Paul's first reflex was to doubt. He caught himself: he'd have believed her.

Words I use

‘Aggressive’, ‘too much’, ‘difficult’: did you apply these to a Black woman where you'd have chosen other words?

Believing her

Write: ‘When a Black woman describes what she lives, I believe her — by default.’

→ *I spot the double standard — and I correct it.*

Restoring their full humanity

Deconstructing misogynoir means granting Black women the same nuance, the same vulnerability, the same benefit of the doubt as anyone else — neither ‘strong’ by obligation, nor objects.

Listen and believe, rather than projecting a stereotype.

Example

By no longer expecting a Black friend to ‘handle everything’, Inès finally left her room to be tired, simply human.

The same humanity

Where do you expect more strength / less fragility from a Black woman than from others?

Listen & amplify

A Black woman whose voice you can listen to / relay (instead of speaking for her): _____

→ *I grant them the same full and whole humanity.*

Changing concretely

Concretely: be quiet and listen, amplify their voices without replacing them, don't impose the 'strong woman' role, interrupt misogynoir around you, and welcome feedback without fragility.

Change is measured by your actions, not your good intentions.

Example

In a meeting, when a Black colleague's idea was ignored then taken up by someone else, Yann re-credited her out loud. Small act, real impact.

My action

One way to act this week (listen, amplify, re-credit, interrupt): _____

Without fragility

Write: 'If a Black woman flags a bias to me, I listen — I don't defend myself.'

→ *I change in action — listen, amplify, re-credit.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Misogynoir stacks two biases (race + gender) — spot both.
- Notice when you judge a Black woman more harshly ('aggressive' vs 'assertive').
- Believe Black women when they speak about their experience.
- Don't impose the 'strong woman' role; don't hypersexualize them.
- Listen and amplify instead of speaking for them.
- Welcome feedback without fragility — impact matters more than your intention.

To fill in

My double standard

Word / judgment applied	What I'd have said for another

My actions

Action (listen, amplify...)	When

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Know the stereotypes and their origin.

Week 2 — Spot my double standard.

Week 3 — Restore the same humanity (listen, believe).

Week 4 — Act: amplify, re-credit, interrupt.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The double standard I correct:
- The voice I'll listen to / amplify:
- My first concrete action:

TO CLOSE

Unlearning misogynoir means restoring Black women's full humanity.

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This guide is a reflection and psychoeducation tool for deconstructing your own biases — not therapy. Deconstruction is ongoing work: discomfort is part of the path, but the goal remains real impact on the people affected, not your comfort. ©

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